> thousands more dead behind, and then revealing their true nature by demolishing the markets of Kabul and promptly returning to India. They had hoped to establish themselves in Afghanistan, to block any Russian advance – but for all the treasure they expended and for all the lives they sacrificed, the only result was ruin and disgrace. If the English had been able to conquer and keep Afghanistan, would they ever have left a land where 44 different types of grapes grow, and other fruits as well – apples, pomegranates, pears, rhubarb, mulberries, sweet watermelon and musk-melon, apricots and peaches? And ice-water, that cannot be found in all the plains of India?

'The Anglo-Indian invasion of Afghanistan', which had wasted money, military equipment and soldiers' lives, 'both black and white', had been, he wrote,

> an unequal fight between treacherous Indian crows and brave Afghan hawks: whenever they took one mountain, the next mountain was always still left in open rebellion. In truth the English would never ever, even after years and years, have managed to pacify Khorasan. The English with their crow-like Indian troops stayed with their bones scattered and unburied on the mountain-slopes of Afghanistan, while the brave Afghan fighters looked for martyrdom, and were victorious in this world and the next: blessed they are indeed who taste the cup of martyrdom![125]

Whether or not Mirza 'Ata's ghazis received the blessings they were expecting either in post-war Afghanistan or in paradise, it was certainly true that very few of those who participated in the war, especially those on the Anglo-Sadozai side, saw their lives prosper in any way. Even before the war, many Afghans had warned the British that a curse was attached to the *kumbukht* [that unlucky rascal] Shah Shuja, who always saw his best-laid plans end in disaster.[126] Now, long after Shuja's death, this bad luck seemed to be passed on to any who were involved in his attempt to depose Dost Mohammad.

Ranjit Singh, Burnes, Vitkevitch and Macnaghten were already long dead, while Wade had been sacked from his jealously guarded position on the Frontier at the request of the Khalsa and had been bundled off to the less important Residency at Indore in central India. Burnes's unfortunate Suffolk dray horses that he had escorted up the Indus with such trouble had also passed on: Ranjit Singh soon lost interest in them once it became clear that they were incapable of charging. They were penned up and soon died as no one in Lahore knew what to do with them.